HIGHTOWER BIBLE MINISTRY

Following Christ

Learning, Growing, and Living God's Word

PART 1 — LEARN GOD'S WORD

Lessons 1–3

PURPOSE
These lessons are original Hightower Bible Ministry discipleship material designed to help a believer know who Jesus is, understand the Gospel, and develop biblical assurance of belonging to Christ.

Teaching Rhythm

Read it • Understand it • Believe it • Live it

LESSON 1

Who Is Jesus Christ?

Knowing the Person at the center of the Christian faith

Primary Scriptures: John 1:1–18; Colossians 1:15–20

BIG IDEA

Jesus Christ is the eternal Son of God who became truly human, reveals God to us, created all things, holds first place over all creation, and brings reconciliation through His death.

What You Will Explore

- What John means when he calls Jesus "the Word."
- Why Jesus is not merely a teacher, prophet, or created being.
- What it means that the Word became flesh.
- Why Colossians describes Christ as supreme over creation and the Church.
- How the identity of Jesus should change the way we trust and follow Him.

Opening Life Situation

People use the name Jesus in many different ways. Some describe Him as a great moral teacher. Others see Him mainly as a prophet, miracle worker, a god, or religious leader. The New Testament makes much greater claims. Before we can understand what it means to follow Jesus, we must first ask: Who does Scripture say He is?

Read It

Read John 1:1–18 and Colossians 1:15–20 slowly in your preferred Bible translation. Circle or write down every title, description, action, or claim made about Jesus Christ.

What descriptions of Jesus stand out to you?

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Observation — What Does the Text Say?

1. In John 1:1–3, what is said about the Word before creation began?
2. According to John 1:3, what relationship does the Word have to everything that was made?
3. What happened in John 1:14 that brought the eternal Word into human history?
4. In Colossians 1:16–17, what things were created through Christ and for Christ?
5. What words in Colossians 1:18–20 describe Christ's position, purpose, and work?

Interpretation — What Does It Mean?

John begins before Bethlehem. The Word already existed “in the beginning.” He was with God, and John identifies the Word as divine. John then says that all created things came into existence through Him. That means Jesus belongs on the Creator side of the Creator–creation distinction.

When John says that the Word became flesh, he does not mean that Jesus stopped being divine. The eternal Son truly entered human life. Christianity therefore centers on the incarnation: the One who reveals God to us came among us as a real human being.

Colossians calls Christ the “firstborn” over all creation. In the flow of the passage, this describes His supremacy and rank, not that He was the first creature made. Paul immediately explains that all things were created through Him and for Him and that He is before all things.

BIBLICAL TRUTH

Jesus Christ is not simply one messenger among many. He is the eternal Son, Creator, Lord, and visible revelation of the invisible God. He deserves first place in our faith, worship, thinking, and daily life.

Christ-Centered Application

If Jesus is who Scripture says He is, He cannot be reduced to an adviser whom we consult only when convenient. Following Christ means trusting His authority, listening to His Word, depending on His saving work, and learning to place Him first.

Live It — Personal Application

1. Write three truths about Jesus from these passages that you want to remember this week.
2. Identify one area of life where you have treated Jesus more like an adviser than Lord.
3. Pray specifically that your view of Christ would be shaped more by Scripture than by culture, habit, or assumption.

One truth about Jesus that changes the way I see Him is:

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MEMORY VERSE

John 1:14 — Read it in your preferred translation and work on memorizing the reference and central truth: the eternal Word became flesh and lived among us.

LESSON 2

The Gospel and Salvation

Understanding God's gracious rescue through Jesus Christ

Primary Scriptures: Romans 3:23; Romans 5:8; Romans 6:23; Ephesians 2:8–10; 1 Corinthians 15:3–4

BIG IDEA

Salvation is God's gracious rescue of sinners through the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. It is received through faith, not earned by good works, and it produces a new life of obedience.

What You Will Explore

- Why every person needs salvation.
- What sin has done to our relationship with God.
- What Jesus accomplished through His death and resurrection.
- Why salvation is a gift of grace rather than a reward for good behavior.
- How good works fit into the Christian life after salvation.

Opening Life Situation

Ask several people what makes someone right with God and you may hear answers such as, "I try to be a good person," "I help people," "I go to church," or "I have never done anything really terrible." The Gospel begins somewhere else. It begins with what God says about our condition and what God has done for us in Christ.

Read It

Read the primary Scriptures above. As you read, look for four movements: our condition, God's love, Christ's work, and our response.

Observation — What Does the Text Say?

1. According to Romans 3:23, what is true of all people?
2. What does Romans 6:23 contrast with the wages of sin?
3. According to Romans 5:8, when did God demonstrate His love toward us?
4. What does Ephesians 2:8–9 say salvation is based on — grace, works, or both?
5. According to Ephesians 2:10, what place do good works have after we are saved?
6. What two historical events are central to the Gospel in 1 Corinthians 15:3–4?

Interpretation — What Does It Mean?

The Bible does not divide humanity into people who need grace and people who have done well enough without it. All have sinned. Sin is more than mistakes or poor choices; it is rebellion against God and falling short of His righteous standard.

The good news is not that we can repair ourselves. God acted in love while we were still sinners. Jesus died for our sins and rose again. His saving work, not our moral record, is the foundation of the Gospel.

Ephesians makes the order clear: we are saved by grace through faith, not by works. Yet the same passage says believers are created in Christ for good works. Good works are the fruit of salvation, not the price paid to obtain it.

THE GOSPEL IN FOUR MOVEMENTS

GOD — holy, loving, and Creator. SIN — we have rebelled and cannot make ourselves right with God. CHRIST — Jesus died for our sins and rose again. RESPONSE — turn to God and trust in Jesus Christ rather than trusting yourself.

Biblical Truth

Salvation rests on God's grace. The Christian does not boast, "I made myself worthy." The believer says, "God showed mercy to me through Jesus Christ." This produces humility, gratitude, worship, and a new desire to live for God.

Christ-Centered Application

The Gospel keeps Jesus at the center. We do not outgrow our need for Christ after conversion. The same grace that saves us continues to shape how we confess sin, forgive others, serve, worship, and depend on God.

Live It — Personal Application

1. In your own words, explain why being a "good person" cannot be the basis of salvation.
2. Write a four-sentence Gospel summary using the headings God, Sin, Christ, and Response.
3. Ask yourself what you are most tempted to trust in besides Christ — good works, church attendance, knowledge, feelings, family background, or something else.

My four-sentence Gospel summary:

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MEMORY VERSE

Ephesians 2:8–9 — Read the passage in your preferred translation and memorize its central truth: salvation is by grace through faith, not a human achievement.

LESSON 3

Can I Know I Belong to Christ?

Building assurance on God's promise rather than changing feelings

Primary Scriptures: John 10:27–29; 1 John 5:11–13; Romans 8:1; Philippians 1:6

BIG IDEA

Biblical assurance rests primarily on God's promise and Christ's saving power, not on emotional confidence or flawless performance. Genuine faith also produces a growing pattern of hearing, following, confessing, and trusting Christ.

What You Will Explore

- Why Christians sometimes struggle with doubt.
- What Jesus promises to those who belong to Him.
- Why assurance should rest on God's testimony rather than our emotions.
- How conviction after sin differs from believing that Christ has abandoned us.
- What healthy evidence of spiritual life can look like over time.

Opening Life Situation

A believer may feel close to God one week and discouraged the next. After failure, temptation, or a difficult season, a person may ask, "Am I really saved?" Feelings matter, but they are not a stable foundation. Scripture directs us to something stronger: the character of God, the promise of Christ, and the truth of the Gospel.

Read It

Read John 10:27–29 and 1 John 5:11–13 carefully. Underline what Christ gives, what Christ's sheep do, and what God wants believers to know.

Observation — What Does the Text Say?

1. In John 10:27, what characteristics identify Jesus' sheep?
2. What does Jesus say He gives them in John 10:28?
3. What statements in John 10:28–29 emphasize security in Christ and the Father?
4. According to 1 John 5:11–12, where is eternal life found?
5. Why did John write these things according to 1 John 5:13?
6. What does Romans 8:1 say about condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus?

Interpretation — What Does It Mean?

Jesus describes His people as those who hear His voice and follow Him. Their security is not presented as the strength of their grip on Christ, but the strength of Christ's grip on them. He gives eternal life, and no created power is stronger than the Father who keeps them.

First John grounds assurance in God's testimony concerning His Son. Assurance therefore should not rise and fall completely with our mood. A believer can feel weak and still rest on a strong promise.

At the same time, assurance is not permission to ignore sin. When believers sin, the proper response is confession, repentance, and renewed trust in Christ. The evidence of life is not sinless perfection but a growing pattern of responding to Christ, His Word, and His correction.

Unstable Foundations vs. Biblical Foundations

Unstable Foundation	Biblical Foundation
"I feel close to God today."	God's promise does not change with my emotions.
"I performed well this week."	My hope rests in Christ's work, not my record.
"I never struggle or doubt."	Faith can seek truth even while feelings are unsettled.
"I can ignore sin because I am secure."	Those who belong to Christ are called to hear and follow Him.

BIBLICAL TRUTH

Assurance grows as we learn to take God at His Word. Christ is a sufficient Savior, the Father is able to keep His people, and the believer is invited to rest in God's testimony while continuing to follow Christ in obedient faith.

Christ-Centered Application

When doubt comes, do not stare endlessly at yourself. Look again to Christ: who He is, what He accomplished, what He promised, and where your trust is placed. Then respond honestly to any known sin and continue following Him.

Live It — When Doubt Comes

1. Ask: What has God actually promised in the passages I have read?
2. Ask: Am I trusting Jesus Christ or trying to make my performance the basis of acceptance?
3. Confess known sin instead of hiding it or using it as proof that grace has failed.
4. Look for a growing direction of life: hearing Christ, following His Word, repentance, love, and obedience.
5. Talk with a mature Christian leader if persistent doubt is keeping you from understanding the Gospel clearly.

The promise from this lesson I most need to remember is:

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MEMORY VERSE

1 John 5:11–13 — Read the passage in your preferred translation and memorize the central truth that God gives life in His Son and wants believers to know where that life is found.

Lessons 1–3 Review

Before moving forward, take a few minutes to explain these three truths without looking back at the lessons. The goal is not simply to finish pages but to understand and live what Scripture teaches.

1. Who is Jesus Christ?

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2. What is the Gospel, and how is a person saved?

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3. What should biblical assurance rest on?

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NEXT STEP

Continue to Lesson 4: Learning to Understand the Bible. HBM will use the same rhythm throughout the course — Read it, Understand it, Believe it, Live it.